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TÜRK TARİH KURUMU
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# The Activities of Maltese Corsairs in Ottoman Waters and Territories 1750-1798

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The Corso in the 18th century Mediterranean was still a major economic activity. Malta was no exception to this. Private ships at Malta kept acquiring letters of marquee to attack Ottoman shipping until 1798. The corsairs at Malta armed on average 10-23 private ships a year. Galleys, Xebecs and Frigates were armed to harass shipping both in the western Mediterranean and in the eastern parts of the middle sea. New evidence from the archives at Malta is revealing an inexhaustible amount of evidence that the Corso was alive and well even during the last years of the Knights of St. John's stay in Malta. The Grandmaster kept issuing licences for corsairing against the Ottoman Empire until his very last days on the island. In this paper I propose to look at the success, failures and audaciousness of Corsair battles, raids and attacks on Ottoman territories and shipping to prove the continuous activity of corsairing in the Mediterranean, far into the future from the days of Barbarossa, Dragut, and Romegas. The author would like to propose that the Corso soldiered on even into the 18th century. Furthermore the present author to suggest a moving away from the notion of piracy, but a hypothesis that corsairing was a legal operation undertaken by warring nations in what was a complex socio-political state of affairs in the Mediterranean.

From the onset one must be clear that the ships and men we will concern ourselves with in this paper are privately owned ships, a separate entity from the Order's official navy. The crew, ships and armaments were essentially privately owned. The owners of the latter pledged their services to the state of Malta in exchange for a letter of Marque from the head of the state, in this case the Grandmaster. In return the Order of St. John expected certain percentages from the eventual profits made at auction of the captured goods. In principal, the Order of St. John was making use of the tried and tested method of privateering. The Order did put at the disposal of the Corsairs certain resources however it was probably gaining more than it was giving out. Diplomatically the Order of St. John was losing favour with certain European states due to the Corso however the benefits of this seemed to have outweighed the problems they were causing with the European powers who were essentially the protectors of this religious Order. The Corso was even upsetting the Papal See, the de-facto leader of the Order. Nonetheless the Grandmaster chose to slither his way through diplomatic hurdle after hurdle and kept up this most contentious of economic activity.

The battles which were conducted by the Corsairs in the late eighteenth century are a complex issue in the history of the Mediterranean. The way in which the battles were conducted are intricate and highly controversial. A corsair which left Malta in search of enemy shipping had to abide by certain rules and regulations. The Tribunale degli Armamenti which regulated the corso had gone through nearly two hundred years of controlling the corsair war. This tribunal regulated in essence the way battles were fought. As such by the period in question the evolution of the Maltese tribunal, had achieved a great level of experience. Ambiguities in captures were still encountered regularly even after so many years of operation. The following are some examples of encounters which show the complications with which the tribunal was faced with on a regular basis. These ambiguities arose from the numerous sea battles a corsair fought in order to maximise upon his creditors' investments.

The less complicated attacks were those on an Ottoman ship with an Ottoman crew. Everything and anything was good game aboard such a ship. In 1785 Captain Zelalich cited an enemy londra. The order was given to beat to quarters. Zelalich's frigate started discharging its cannons, and as the ships got closer, grape shot was used. The grape shot started tearing up the rigging, the closer the Maltese crew steered their ship towards the londra the easier it was for the Maltese sailors to use their muskets. By this point the londra was in a terrible state and the Turkish crew surrendered to Captain Zelalich. The Turks had lost ten men while Zelalich had three of his men injured. It was important to subdue the enemy ship, but not to sink it, as if the ship sank, so would the cargo, and so would the profits.

When faced with the prospect of fighting a Maltese corsair, numerous Turks abandoned their ships and cargo rather than stand and fight. On the 21 November 1781 aboard the frigate of Captain Simone Cavasso, the captain was informed by one of the seamen; who was standing as a look out on a nearby promontory, that a small Turkish xebec was entering a nearby inlet. Cavasso ordered that half of his crew, well armed with muskets and cutlasses should land on the island and approach the enemy from the shore, while his caique should be armed with some of his men to out flank the xebec. The caique would also block any attempt the enemy ship would make to sail out of the inlet. When the Turkish sailors realised that theirs was a desperate situation they abandoned ship taking all valuables with them, Cavasso's landing party had not reached the beach yet and the Turks managed to escape. The newly captured ship was found empty with only some bails of tobacco. The xebec was taken as a prize, but the more lucrative prizes had all been taken off before the Maltese Corsairs could lay their hands on them.

Capture by Maltese Corsairs meant slavery for any Muslim Ottoman subject. Taeis, son of Hales from Aleppo, fell into slavery at the age of seventy. The old men had fallen on hard times and he had decided to leave Cyprus to look for a job as a teacher in some Greek island. Out at sea, Taeis had fallen asleep, when suddenly he

was awakened by the sound of cannon. Startled he asked one of the sailor what was going on. He was told that they had been trapped by a Maltese corsair and the order had been given to abandon ship. He was unable to swim and therefore he had to remain on the ship along with some other Greeks. Taeis was captured and brought to Malta as a slave and he gave his testimony at the tribunal were we got to know his story. Strangely enough there were also instances were Turkish ships refused to fight against the Maltese corsairs, and they instantly gave themselves up. Captain Valentini in 1791 chased a Turkish carabo which was manned by fourteen Turks. As Valentini got closer ready to engage the enemy, the Turks gave a signal that they were willing to surrender. Captain Valentini transferred his newly acquired booty to his small felucca and sailed back to Malta immediately. On the 6 November 1791 Captain Michele Picasso aboard his twenty-two gun xebec sighted and enemy xebec. It turned out it was a Tunisian corsair. The Tunisian xebec was manned by forty sailors, while Picasso's xebec was manned by a hundred and thirty. It was folly for the Tunisians to put up a fight, they immediately surrendered and Picasso sent over a prize crew aboard the ship. As the prize crew boarded the ship, the sea became very rough and the prize crew had to spend the night on the enemy ship as best they could. On the morrow Captain Picasso managed to restore communication between the two ships and he was pleased to know that the newly captured prize was a well armed xebec which would yield great profits back at Malta. The xebec with it all its armaments would be later on bought at auction at Malta by Gaetano Schembri for 1299 scudi.

At times battles proved indecisive, on the 30 June 1794 Captain Giuseppe Grech was chasing three unidentified ships, when at sunset out of nowhere an enemy corsair pounced on Grech's Pink. Caught by surprise the Pink received one full broadside, Grech's crew responded with five discharges, and the enemy fearing the worst abandoned the engagement.

Not all captures were as straight forward as these. There were other complications which arose, that would at times prove disastrous back

at the law courts in Malta. Various examples can be reproduces to explain the great variations of the depredations: Captain Giuseppe Estaden in 1776 aboard his Galleot had been informed that at anchor in a nearby harbour were two merchant xebecs. Therefore he waited for night to fall, Estaden armed his boarding crew and sailed undetected close to one of the xebecs. Estaden's men boarded the enemy ship easily without any resistance. The enemy was caught by surprise; they rounded up the captured crew discovering that they were all Greek. The crew were sixteen in all. Estaden rounded them up and immediately after he stormed the stern cabin finding it full of loaded muskets and two loaded cannons. He turned to the captured Greeks and asked them what flag they were carrying, the Greeks did not reply and Estaden was convinced that this was a pirate ship. Suddenly one of his men shouted out that he had found a Turkish pennant. That meant that this was a legal prize and the cargo was good game, though the crew could not be touched. On a thorough search of the vessel Estaden found four hundred and twenty Turkish piastres. The Greek captain claimed that was all he had. With pistol in hand Captain Estaden asked the Greek Captain were the rest of the Turkish money was. Estaden threatened that if the Greeks did not comply he would burn the ship down. Instantly the Greek Captain handed over four hundred more piastre to Captain Estaden. The Maltese corsairs then retreated back to their galleot, as there was nothing left to take, as the rest belonged to Greeks. Such attacks and battles can go a long way in explaining the great complications which were encountered during the various attacks.

In 1796 close to the island of Santorini, Captain Felice Micallef sent his felucca into the narrow straits of the island into the harbour to enrol some sailors. As he waited for the felucca's return, the crew of his corvette sighted a large ship. All hands beat to quarters, and the standard of the prince of Malta was raised with the sound of one cannon shot. Instantly the unidentified ship hoisted Turkish colours. The lower sails were dropped and every one of the corvettes crews hurried to his battle stations. The two ships got closer to each other and Micallef fired around fifty shots from his twos and sixes. As the ship got even closer the sweeping fire from the

muskets and blunderbusses was causing havoc on the enemy. The Ottoman ship responded with terribly accurate fire power, hitting Micallef's powder magazine and totally destroying the jib sail. The two ships got locked together in a bitter struggle. Micallef fired around three hundred musket shots and two hundred blunderbuss shots. The battle ensued for nearly three hours, with no ship gaining the upper hand. Micallef gave the order to board the enemy ship, as he gave the order, the Gozitan soldier Giuseppe Cassar, and Michele Zammit from Bormla were shot dead, next to them lay also the badly injured Neapolitan sailor Francesco Ebole. Micallef explained that this discouraged his men so much that none had the courage to jump on the enemy ship. In the mean time the look out of the corvette reported that the felucca which had been sent by the captain to Santorini was being towed out of harbour by an enemy ship. Micallef who had already lost two of his men and envisaging a stale mate in his current situation, decided to retreat and tried to save his recently deprived felucca from the clutches of the enemy. With some difficulty he dislodged his corvette and scurried to the aid of his felucca. As Captain Felice Micallef got closer to the ship which had his felucca in tow, it transpired that his felucca crew had overpowered the enemy crew and managed to capture an enemy cherlenghicco. It was a brave act to deprive such a vastly superior ship, and Micallef was extremely happy with the outcome of the battle. But on a closer look, it turned out that the newly captured cherlenghicco had a mixed crew of Turks and Greeks, and Micallef had only a legal claim to half of it. Micallef decided to take a gamble, he manned the cherlenghicco with some of his man and he sailed it to Malta. Back on the island a long a tedious lawsuit ensued which would drag on for months.

Corsairs had the right according to the law of the time to stop Greek ships. This way they could check if the cargo had a passport signed by the Grandmaster or by any other Christian head of state. If so, the corsairs were bound by the law not to molest that ship. Nonetheless it was well known that anyone could acquire a fake passport. Captain Pietro Zelalich in 1785 encounter a Tartana which upon inspection it was discovered that all the papers aboard the Tartana were fake as to deceive the corsairs.

It was also common for Greek merchants to refuse checks by the Maltese corsairs, and at times Corsair captains went to great lengths to stop Greek merchants from doing so. In late 1790 Captain Lorenzo Stafrag was sailing close to the Greek archipelago, and at the Port of Pellarizzo he got to know that a large Greek Merchantmen was in harbour. Stafrag ordered the larger part of his crew to land on the island incognito, carrying with them one of the Stafrag galleot's cannon. The crew from a top a cliff overlooking the harbour were the Greek cherlenghicco was anchored built a small temporary artillery battery. Then Stafrag gave the order to run out the cannon, followed by the order to hoist Grandmaster De Rohan's flag. The baffled Greek captain was immediately approached by Stafrag to present his papers. The Greek Captain refused to do so claiming he was a Christian, so were his crew and his merchandise belonged to Christians. Stafrag did not believe the captain and he trained his cannon at the ship threatening to sink the Greek merchant in harbour. Suddenly the Pappas of the island, came hurriedly to speak to Stafrag. The Pappas demanded an answer to why had Stafrag so audaciously set up a gun platform, with the Grandmaster's standard on Greek soil. Stafrag threatened the Pappas that if the Greek ship did present his papers Stafrag would sink the Greek cherlenghicco.

The Pappas took a position of a mediator and convinced the Greek captain to speak to Stafrag. The Greek captain rowed to land on his tender boat, so that he could speak to Captain Stafrag. The Greek said that the Cherlenghiccio was his, all the crew were Greek christians but the merchandise was all Turkish. On board he had two merchants one was a Turk the other was a Jew. His ship was loaded with soap di pietra sicli, dates, almonds, pine nuts, rubber, sulphur, cinnamon, and a large number of various pieces of cloths, especially fine Levantine red silk. Captain Lorenzo Stafrag told the captain that he (Stafrag) was going to take over the cherlenghiccio ship and sail it to Malta. He would pay the captains fare back to his home, but this ship was now in the hands of the Maltese corsairs. The Greek reluctantly accepted the conditions; he further added that all his crew were to be unmolested and landed in Pellerizzo except two sailors which were to accompany the captain to Malta. Stafrag

accepted these demands, and set about securing all his munitions, and goods on board the newly acquired cherlenghicco. Captain Lorenzo Stafrag gave the order for his old galleot to be abandoned, he set fire to it and manned the cherlenghicco with his crew and sailed to Malta arriving on the 15 February 1791.

At times Greeks refused to give in to the threats of the Maltese Corsairs, and a Corsair would lose his temper. Such loss of temper could result in the Captain being charged with misconduct. Captain Leopoldo Desira in 1781 could not get a confession from his newly arrested Greek sailors. He believed that the merchandise the Greeks had on board was Turkish, nonethless the Greek denied this accusation. Desira ordered his men to tie the Greek sailors to the cannons and he flogged them until they admitted the cargo was Turkish. Such behaviour got Captain Desira into a lot of trouble at the tribunal back in Malta.

Not all Greeks were treated as badly, Greeks who had been deprived of their Turkish ship and had no means with which to return home were at times landed on friendly shores. Captain Gerolamo Ricardi had just captured a Turkish ship with a Greek crew, the ship was deprived, yet the crew were not molested and they were landed on the island of Calderini. Benevolently Ricardi gave the crew, bread, cheese and money. Furthermore he handed the Greek Captain extra money for his son who was travelling with his father on the Greek ship. On the 4 December 1787 Captain Giorgio Mitrovich was sailing aboard his xebec when his lookout sighted a brigantine with a Turkish flag. Instantly the caique of Mitrovich was despatched to chase the ship. The brigantine immediately stopped and peacefully showed all the paper to the Maltese corsairs. The stopped ship was commanded by a Greek, manned by Greek sailors with a Russian passenger, nothing on board was deemed as good game. The caique returned to the ship and the Brigantine was left to continue its voyage.

Another procedure undertaken by the Maltese corsairs was to stop a Greek ship and sell to the captain or a passenger the Turkish

cargo that the Greek ship was carrying. Captain Salvatore Fabri was working under the command of Captain Leopoldo Desira when he deprived a small inshore boat loaded with construction wood. The Greek Captain explained that all his crew were Greek Orthodox and so was the passenger on the boat; who was a Pappas, nevertheless the construction wood belonged to a Turk. Fabri claiming the wood as a fair prize decided to save the time and effort of transferring the captured cargo to Captain Desira's ship and so he offered the wood to the Pappas. The Pappas gladly obliged and bought the construction wood for 200 piastre. Fabri gave the Pappas a receipt of their transaction. On it he wrote a small message explaining what had happened as well as adding:

"I would like to beg all friendly corsairs to respect our old custom and refrain from molesting this ship until it reaches a port where it can offload the merchandise I Captain Salvatore Fabri have sold"

At times the corsairs employed tactics which baffle the scholar in their audacity. Captain Giuseppe Grech kidnapped the young daughter of the governor of the island of Sira. He then offered back the girl to her father the governor for 350 piastre. The said sum was paid straight away. Unfortunately we have no details of how this was done. As this information is extracted from the profits accounted for towards the end of the log book of the cruise.

There is also evidence available that shows that at times unnecessary risk were not taken, and a Captain would give the order to retreat. On the 31 July 1794 Captain Giuseppe Grech was chasing an enemy Germa. The Germa proved very hard to catch and Grech was trying to subdue it by firing his long range guns at it. He fired twelve shots in all until the Germa sailed close to shore, were Captain Giuseppe Grech could notice a large amassment of enemy cavalry, and the order was given to abandon the enterprise.

On the 24 January 1794, Captain Giuseppe Grech, and Captain Giuseppe Galea were working in conserva. They had been chasing for some time a square sailed ship, which after a few hours turned out

to be a corvette of the Grand Seignior. The two corsairs surrounded the enemy ship leaving it no means of escape suddenly though, close to the island of Paros another ship of the Ottoman navy swooped into view. Suddenly the hunter became the hunted and Galea and Grech had to beat a hasty retreat.

Retreat was ordered when unnecessary risks were apparent during an engagement. In mid April 1792 Captain Benedetto Valentini was sailing close to Sfaxs. He knew that the Venetian Navy was in the area. Venice was at war with Tunis, Valentini took this opportunity to land some of his man to raid some local villages. Venice had sent an army of around eight thousand men on land, and the crew of Valentini's felucca could hear cannon shots in the distance. Two officials and seven sailors were dispatched to raid a local village. As they landed they made their way inland, but some dogs which were in the village started barking and as not to be captured, the landing party retreated back to the felucca.

Maltese corsairs also met with defeat and death during the period under review. Death was a constant reminder of the dangerous business the corsairs were conducting. If victory came at a cost, defeat was even dearer. After a battle or engagement, the havoc would have been considerable. In victory, the doctor on board (referred to in the documents as the Chirurgo) went round in caring for the wounded, while the clerk noted all the casualties which had been succoured during battle. Captain Gaetano Cavasso was sailing in the Levant when he was attacked by an Alexandrian ship of the line. The enemy vessel had superior fire power nonetheless Cavasso attacked his foe. From nine o'clock in the morning till night fall the two ships were locked in a continuous chase, gaining inches on each other, neither one of them gained the upper hand. By night fall the superior number of cannons the enemy was starting to take its toll. Cavasso gave the order to abandon the fight and take flight in order to save his vessel and his crew. After such a long battle three men lay dead while three were badly injured. Battle casualties also included enemy sailors, which succumbed to their injuries endured during battle. Captain Pietro Zelalich in 1785 was sailing close to the City

of Namor in Cyprus. The Captain chased an enemy londra for three hours. The ensuing fire from the enemy ship caused injuries to one of his lieutenants and two of his sailors. When the enemy was finally subdued it transpired that ten of the captured enemy crew lay dead, and the londra was sinking fast. The captain decided to abandon the prize.

Another example of the cost of victory was endured by some of the crew of Captain Zelalich. In early October 1785 Zelalich's vaxxel, chased a suspicious tartana off the coast of Alexandria. Zelalich fired numerous broadsides towards the tartana which was trying to escape. Eventually the tartana surrendered. When aboard the newly capture prize Zelalich found various false passports on board, and it was decided to sail the ship to Malta and let the Tribunale decide if the latter was a legitimate prize. The newly captured tartana was now manned by eleven Maltese sailors, two prize captains, a guardiano and four Greeks which were part of the original crew. To assist the prize crew in their journey back to Malta the captain gave the prize captains two nautical charts, a compass, munitions, victuals, wine and water. Captain Zelalich ordered the tartana to sail and follow with the mother ship. At first the journey back was plain sailing, until terrible weather hit the two ships. The heavy seas that ensued forced the ships away from each other. Things got worse when the captured prize hit a reef, and the tartana's planks started coming apart, and water started gushing into the hold violently. At once it was decided to abandon ship, the Tartana's caique was lowered and all the men boarded the small boat as best they could. It was decided to try and catch up with the mother ship rather than risk falling into slavery. They rowed as hard as they could but everybody was too tired and the caique could not catch up with Zelalich's ship. With no water available, and night soon approaching their only hope was to risk landing in Egypt. As they rowed close to land they landed in a small village called Matar. All the crew was instantly assailed by Berbers. The exhausted corsairs could not put up a fight and everybody surrendered immediately. The Greeks who had been on the tartana immediately showed their true colours and started pleading with their new Egyptian masters that they were not in

fact Greek at all but Turks. Nevertheless their new masters did not release them from their shackles. The elders of Matar then divided their new human merchandise between themselves. Some took one slave others took two. After a few days had passed a Turkish ship anchored close to the village and bought all the slaves from their respective masters. What happened next is unclear, what is sure is that Bernardo Caruana and Carlo Schembri convinced their new master into helping them escape. They gave him some money which they had hidden on themselves and they convinced him to take them to Alexandria were they would acquire the rest of their ransom. In Alexandria their master took them, to some friars which lived in the city. These friars with the help of a certain merchant from Livorno called Lenzi, managed to put together enough money donated from the local Christian community to bribe their master into letting his slaves go. The two Maltese slaves were taken into the care of the friars who hid them in their monastery. The friars then managed to embark the two men illegally on a Venetian ship. At sea they were told that they were to jump ship. They came across an English ship bound for Livorno and so the two boarded the English ship. At Livorno the two Maltese corsairs finally found passage to Malta on a ship from Ragusa. After such an ordeal it must have been such a relief to arrive back in Malta. The two sailors Bernardo Caruana and Carlo Schembri related their escape to the Harbour officials at the Lazzaretto on the 4 February 1786.

Falling into slavery was an ordeal that terrified most sailors. Many stories have survived about sailors falling into slavery. Out of a crew of around a hundred men, Captain Giorgio Mitrovich had the misfortune in having to report back in Malta that eleven of his crew had fallen into slavery during his campaign of 1777. The Maltese Corsairs had a variety of mishaps throughout the period in question. In 1776 Captain Leopoldo Desira was sailing aboard his felucca close to Xlendi at Gozo when he was suddenly assailed by Turkish Corsairs. His ship was taken over by the Turks and Desira was lucky to escape with his life. Captain Salvatore Fabri as well met with disaster, this time in the Levant; his large felucca was badly damaged, and was nearly shipwrecked in mid 1779. Captain Fabri was at least

able to limp back to Marsamxett Harbour. Captain Estaden was not as lucky as Captain Desira and Captain Fabri to escape with his life after being defeated. In what probably was his last campaign in 1779, Captain Giuseppe Estaden was attacked and overpowered by a xebec of Gissanclose to Fontana Amorosa in the waters of Cyprus.

One of the last recorded defeats of a Maltese Corsair Captain was ironically that of one of the most active and successful of the last decade of the Corso. Captain Michele Picasso had left Malta sometime in late April 1797; his xebec La Beata Vergine dellle Grazie left Malta for the Levant. On the 1 July 1797 the xebec was ambushed by two large ships of the Grand Seignior. Picasso and his men had no chance of putting up a fight against such superior opposition. The xebec was abandoned under orders of the Captain. Picasso, the clerk, the doctor and some of the crew launched the small tender boat of the xebec and managed to escape on the boat while evading capture. It is very probable that not all of the sixty souls on board escaped. The few men that did escape, rowed as hard as they could away from the battle, and after a few days of sailing in an open boat they were saved by a French Republican Cutter. All the survivors were taken to the now French controlled island of Zante (Zakynthos). The republican government officials on the island helped the routed corsairs to acquire a small felucca with which they could return to Malta were they finally arrived in 1798. The Maltese Corsairs had been saved by the same navy which within a few months would overrun Malta under the guise of General Bonaparte.

Encounters with enemy ships were the tools with which the corsairs achieved their most important aim; procuring profits. Vigilance, caution, courage, audaciousness and a good deal of luck would ensure a profitable outcome for all. Dangers were still very real, and any sailor be it the captain or the most common of sailors, knew that a return home to Malta was not always guaranteed. Battles have been discussed in an attempt to gain a better understanding of the Maltese corsairs. The recorded battles and their frequency have been put forward as a hypothesis for a continuation of the corsair economy on Malta. This is a far cry from the decline which is

usually attributed to the second half of the 18th century. The current author would like to propose a hypothesis of an uninterrupted corsair activity throughout the 18th century on the evidence we have at present. The corsair's adversaries in battle have at times been erroneously portrayed as victims of Maltese or 'catholic pirates.' It has been my intention to propose a modification of such claims. The corsairs were commerce raiders, in tune with the attitudes of the time and of contemporary maritime edicts which were well within the international laws of the early modern Mediterranean. Corsairs were not pirates, but lawful combatants who had to abide by certain rules of war. The corsair or privateer policy, however volatile, yielded handsome profits to the state coffers at the expense of another state and the Order of St. John mimicked other international powers of the time.